detail that she ‘sang in the moonlight on the road to Lagham in 1549’) and Salima Sultan Begum, widow of Bairam Khan and wife of Akbar.

Apart from Salima Sultan Begum, who was the only wife of the Padshah to be included, these were all senior Mughal women, enormously respected by Akbar. They carried with them the Timurid legacy of journeying from the time of Babur and Humayun. It is a testimony to the respect and influence these women commanded that Akbar allowed them to make the pilgrimage, for the hajj was a dangerous and unpredictable journey. There was the risk of piracy, of shipwreck, of abduction, of drowning, as well as the many dangers of travelling in the Holy Lands themselves. In fact, this party of women would be delayed for a year at Surat while the Portuguese prevaricated with the cartaz, they would flounder off the coast of Aden on the way back, and be marooned for a year while they waited for a ship to rescue them. They would bring back from the Holy Lands tales of many exciting adventures, the satisfaction of bestowing largesse on the devout that was so ostentatious that they were chastised by the Ottoman authorities themselves, and also the confidence of pious Muslim women who had completed the hajj. When they returned to Fatehpur Sikri, they would make the stay of the Jesuit priests untenable.

It is generally believed that the women’s hajj was organized and headed by Gulbadan, the irrepressible and beloved aunt of Akbar’s who had endured so many reversals as she followed in the wake of her father and brother, Padshahs of Hindustan. Akbar, too, was no doubt eager to sponsor the hajj, a visible and opulent symbol for a Muslim ruler to display. Akbar ‘sent with her [Gulbadan] a large amount of money and goods’ and indeed he ‘poured into the lap of each the money that they wanted and so made the burden of their desires light’. He enlarged the pious trust (waqf), which had been set up by the last Sultan of Gujarat to send the revenues of a number of coastal villages as donations to the Holy Lands. Several thousand robes of honour and enormous sums of money for charity were also sent by Akbar with the party. Akbar sponsored the building of a hospice in Mecca and from 1575 onwards would send a hajj caravan under a special Mughal officer known as the mir hajj every year from Hindustan, rivalling the great hajj caravans of Egypt and Syria and threatening the very power of the Ottoman Sultan, whose sole prerogative it was to arrange for these caravans. ‘A general permission was given to the people’ agreed Badauni, ‘so that at great public expense, with gold and goods and rich presents, the